

Natchez Trace Parkway

Lower Trace Self-Guided Cycling Tour
Natchez, MS → Rocky Springs, MS
Your route. Your pace. Your adventure.

TOTAL DISTANCE	DURATION	DIFFICULTY	BIKE TYPE	BEST SEASON
~82 Miles	3 Days	Beginner	Road or Hybrid	Spring / Fall

ESSENTIAL INFORMATION

START POINT	Natchez Visitor Center, Natchez, MS (Milepost 0)
END POINT	Rocky Springs Campsite, MS (Milepost 54.8)
CAMPING	Free NPS designated campsites — no reservation needed
LODGING	B&Bs; and motels in Natchez and Port Gibson
RESUPPLY	Natchez (start), Port Gibson (MP 39.2) — stock up, limited options between
CASH	Bring cash — many small towns and local restaurants are cash only
CELL SERVICE	Spotty in many sections — download offline maps before departing
TRAFFIC	No trucks or commercial vehicles ever permitted on the Parkway
WATER	Available at NPS visitor centers and campgrounds — carry 2L minimum between stops
EMERGENCY	NPS Ranger Station: (601) 446-6672 · Call 911 for emergencies

DAY 1 — ARRIVAL & NATCHEZ EXPLORATION (0 miles riding)

Arrive in Natchez — one of the oldest cities on the Mississippi River and the southern terminus of the Trace. Spend the afternoon exploring the historic downtown, the Mississippi bluffs, and the antebellum mansions that made this one of pre-Civil War America's wealthiest cities. Dine along the bluffs tonight — the Mississippi catfish here is exceptional.

HIGHLIGHT	DETAILS	NOTES
Natchez Bluffs	Stunning overlooks of the Mississippi River	Best at sunset
Antebellum Mansions	Stanton Hall, Longwood, Dunleith — tours available	Book ahead in spring
Downtown Natchez	Historic Main Street, local restaurants, shops	Cash for local spots
Overnight	Natchez B&B; district — charming antebellum inns	See accommodations list

DAY 2 — NATCHEZ TO PORT GIBSON (~42 miles · ~2,100 ft elevation)

Your first day of riding begins at the Natchez Visitor Center. The Parkway wraps you in forest and calm immediately. Keep eyes open for deer, wild turkey, and armadillos in the early miles. Smooth NPS pavement, light car traffic, and your pace entirely your own.

MILE	CUE / LANDMARK	DIR	NOTES
0.0	Natchez Visitor Center — START	Head N	Parking, restrooms, water. Official Parkway start.
1.2	Under-the-Hill area	Continue N	Optional last coffee/food stop before the Trace.
10.3	Emerald Mound	Turn R	MUST STOP. 2nd largest Native American mound in US. Sunrise here is magical. Allow 30 min.
15.5	Mount Locust Historic Inn	Continue N	Oldest remaining inn on the Old Natchez Trace. NPS interpretive site.
17.5	Loess Bluff	Continue N	Unique geological formation. Short walk to overlook.
25.0	Sunken Trace	Continue N	Walk the original sunken trail worn by centuries of foot traffic.
30.0	Grindstone Ford / Mangum Mound	Continue N	Ancient mound and creek crossing. Good shaded rest stop.
35.0	Coles Creek Picnic Area	Continue N	Good lunch stop. Restrooms and water available.
39.2	PORT GIBSON — END DAY 2	Exit L	Turn left toward town. Motels and B&Bs.; RESUPPLY HERE for Day 3.

★ *PORT GIBSON OVERNIGHT: First Presbyterian Church (the Golden Hand steeple) is a must-see on your evening walk. The Corner on Church B&B; is highly recommended. Dinner: Piney Woods Restaurant for local Southern cooking.*

DAY 3 — PORT GIBSON TO ROCKY SPRINGS (~40 miles · ~2,400 ft elevation)

Today features the single most memorable detour on the Lower Trace — the Windsor Ruins. Plan extra time. The day ends at Rocky Springs, a ghost town slowly reclaimed by forest, where the free NPS campsite sits among ruins of what was once a community of 2,600 people.

MILE	CUE / LANDMARK	DIR	NOTES
0.0	Port Gibson — START DAY 3	To Pkwy	Stock up food and water. Limited resupply ahead.
1.0	Re-enter Natchez Trace Pkwy	Head N	Resume from MP 39.2. Continue northbound.
41.0	Windsor Ruins Turnoff	Turn LEFT	MUST STOP. Onto Rodney Rd — 0.5 mi to ruins. 23 haunting columns in the forest. Allow 45-60 min.
41.5	Return to Parkway	Turn RIGHT	Rejoin Parkway heading north after Windsor Ruins.
45.7	Sunken Trace (2nd section)	Continue N	Original deeply worn trail. Short walk, very worth it.
47.5	Coles Creek Picnic Area	Continue N	LAST WATER before Rocky Springs. Fill all bottles here.
50.0	Owens Creek Waterfall	Continue N	Small but lovely waterfall. Easy 2-min walk off road.
54.8	Rocky Springs — END DAY 3	Turn R	Free NPS camping. Water at site. Ghost town ruins and 1837 church nearby.

★ *ROCKY SPRINGS CAMP: Water spigot on site. Bear boxes provided. Walk the ghost town trail at dusk — ruins of stores, homes and the standing church are extraordinary. No cell service. Stargazing here is exceptional on clear nights.*

ACCOMMODATION RECOMMENDATIONS

LOCATION	TYPE	NAME / DETAILS	BOOKING
Natchez (Night 1)	B&B;	Dunleith, Monmouth, The Guest House — antebellum inns	Booking.com Book 6+ wks ahead spring
Natchez (Night 1)	Hotel	Natchez Grand Hotel — central, good value	Booking.com
Port Gibson (Night 2)	B&B;	The Corner on Church B&B; — Victorian, excellent hosts	(601) 437-4350 Call direct
Port Gibson (Night 2)	Motel	Gibson Landing — budget option, basic and clean	Booking.com
Rocky Springs (Night 3)	NPS Camp	Rocky Springs Campground — free, first come first served	No reservation needed

RECOMMENDED GEAR FOR THE NATCHEZ TRACE

CATEGORY	ESSENTIALS	NICE TO HAVE
Bike	Road or hybrid bike (any gearing), spare tubes x2, pump, multi-tool, chain lube	Handlebar bag, frame bag for storage
Navigation	Offline maps downloaded (Google Maps or Gaia GPS), this cue sheet	Garmin or Wahoo GPS with GPX loaded
Clothing	Padded shorts, jersey x2, lightweight rain jacket, arm warmers	Chamois cream, sun sleeves for hot days
Camp / Sleep	Lightweight tent, sleeping bag (40F rated), sleeping pad	Camp pillow, ear plugs for wildlife nights
Food & Water	2x bottles minimum, water filter (Sawyer Squeeze), 2 days emergency food	Electrolyte tabs, energy gels for climbs
Safety	Front and rear lights, helmet, ID, emergency contacts, basic first aid	Personal locator beacon for remote sections
Other	Cash \$50+ minimum, sunscreen, insect repellent (essential spring)	Small padlock for bike at overnight stops

NAVIGATION & DIGITAL MAPS

RESOURCE	HOW TO USE	WHERE TO GET IT
GPX File	Import to Garmin, Wahoo, Komoot, Ride with GPS, or Apple Maps	Included in your download package from openride.bike
Ride with GPS	View interactive map, get turn cues on your phone, export GPX	ridewithgps.com — search OpenRide Natchez Trace
Google Maps Offline	Download the region over WiFi before your trip for offline use	Open Google Maps, find area, tap Download
NPS Parkway Map	Official map with all mileposts, facilities, campgrounds marked	nps.gov/natr — free PDF download
Komoot	Excellent cycling-specific routing and navigation app	komoot.com — search Natchez Trace

This route guide was curated by a professional bicycle tour guide with over 10 years of experience leading tours on the Natchez Trace Parkway. Every stop, every note, and every recommendation comes from real miles ridden on this road.

Questions or feedback? Visit openride.bike — and share your ride photos with #OpenRide.